

Collapse of Regulatory Capacity Drives Convergent Phenotypes in Human Cancer

Nate Christensen

SymC Universe Project, Missouri, USA
NateChristensen@SymCUniverse.com

01 February 2026

Abstract

Cancer phenotypes converge on mechanical rigidity and metabolic reprogramming across diverse mutations, suggesting physical constraints beyond genetic drivers. This research analyzed RNA-seq profiles from 20,531 genes across 11,069 TCGA Pan-Cancer Atlas tumors and mapped expression mean (μ) and variability (σ) into a stability index $\chi = \sigma/(2\mu)$, corresponding to a damping ratio $\chi = \gamma/(2\omega)$ with a critical boundary at $\chi \approx 1$. Rank-ordering genes by an energy proxy ($\omega \approx \mu$) reveals a stable high-energy structural regime near the critical boundary, while low-energy signaling modes show a reproducible three-stage sequence (Warning, Confirmation, Collapse) marked by fast and slow trend divergence, dispersion growth, and collapse to trend convergence. This study terms the terminal state *Substrate Capture*: a finite-bandwidth failure in which regulation tracks the destabilized substrate rather than the critical attractor. Together, these results suggest that cancer progression may be constrained by conserved physical limits on regulatory control, motivating state-based diagnostics and interventions that target system stability rather than individual mutations.

Keywords: cancer genomics, critical damping, phase transition, bandwidth collapse, viscoelastic regulation, therapeutic resistance, control theory

1 Introduction

The persistence of the somatic mutation theory in oncology presents a physical paradox. If mutations accumulate stochastically through random DNA damage, why do tumors across diverse tissue types converge on highly deterministic structural phenotypes? Desmoplasia, the pathological stiffening of tumor stroma, occurs with remarkable consistency across pancreatic, breast, and lung cancers. The Warburg effect, metabolic reprogramming toward aerobic glycolysis [2], manifests as a common feature of aggressive malignancy [3]. These are not subtle statistical tendencies but dominant physical signatures that define the cancerous state.

Standard genomic models treat these physical changes as downstream consequences of driver mutations in oncogenes such as KRAS, TP53, or MYC [4, 5]. The implicit logic follows a simple causal chain: mutation disrupts signaling, altered signaling changes metabolism, metabolic changes produce structural remodeling. Yet this narrative struggles to explain several empirical observations. First, tumors with identical driver mutations exhibit wildly heterogeneous responses to targeted therapy, suggesting mutation status alone is insufficient to predict system behavior. Second, the timescale paradox remains unresolved: structural remodeling and metabolic shifts often precede detectable clonal expansion, implying that physical architecture may drive genetic instability rather than result from it. Third, the extraordinary evolutionary convergence across tissue types hints at constraint, not stochasticity.

If cancer were truly a random walk through mutational space, far greater phenotypic diversity than observed would be expected. This work proposes a complementary physical framework to the mutation-centric model. Rather than treating the cell solely as a collection of independent molecular pathways that occasionally fail through genetic error, this analysis models the transcriptome as a *viscoelastic substrate*

governed by the physics of damped oscillation. In this framework, genomic stability is determined by the critical damping ratio $\chi \equiv \gamma/(2\omega)$, which quantifies the balance between dissipation (γ) and restoring force (ω). The hypothesis is that healthy biological systems self-organize to the critical boundary $\chi \approx 1$ to maximize information efficiency within finite control bandwidth S . Cancer may reflect not only random mutation accumulation but also a *control bandwidth failure* where the energetic and temporal cost of maintaining regulation exceeds system capacity.

All results presented derive from empirical TCGA RNA-seq data; no simulated dynamics are used. Temporal structure is inferred from ensemble statistics computed directly from measured data. This analysis applies phase-space analysis to the Pan-Cancer Atlas (PANCAN) dataset, revealing a scale-dependent collapse in regulatory capacity.

This work extends earlier control-physics diagnostics downward into substrate physics while preserving the control-theoretic spine: gene-wise substrate stability defines the landscape upon which patient-wise trajectories evolve. At high energy scales corresponding to structural infrastructure (cytoskeleton, extracellular matrix, metabolic factories), the substrate maintains tight adherence to critical damping, providing stable bandwidth for cellular function. At low energy scales corresponding to regulatory signaling, however, the analysis observes abrupt breakdown through a three-stage diagnostic sequence: the regulatory network ceases tracking the critical stability boundary and instead becomes *captured* by the failing substrate. Across this cohort, bandwidth collapse appears to precede gross phenotypic hallmarks; oncogenic signaling is consistent with an initiating role while structural genes are consistent with an executing role in physical manifestation. Substrate capture shows no reversal in cross-sectional transcriptomic measurements without exceptional-point crossing, and therapeutic resistance is consistent with a physical consequence of viscoelastic rigidity rather than evolutionary adaptation.

Critically, gene-wise stability defines substrate architecture while patient-wise χ reflects projection into a specific tumor realization, maintaining the distinction between landscape (substrate) and dynamics (trajectories). This work does not claim that transcriptomic variance causes malignancy; rather, it reveals conserved control-physics constraints under which diverse molecular drivers converge on the same failure states. *Genomic Regulatory Instability (GRI)* refers to the scale-dependent loss of damping, bandwidth, and reversibility in the transcriptomic stability landscape, culminating in a transition from adaptive regulation to mechanical rigidity.

2 Results

2.1 Theoretical Framework and Architecture

The four-parameter stability architecture separates the stability landscape from the dynamics upon it:

State Space (Stability Landscape):

- ω : Characteristic frequency (energy scale)
- $A \equiv \sigma$: Amplitude of fluctuations (variance)
- S : Control bandwidth (admissible correction range without instability)

Flow (Dynamics on Landscape):

- D : Directionality of evolution (drift, hysteresis, irreversibility)

The stability index $\chi = \gamma/(2\omega) = \sigma/(2\mu)$ is a *local property* computed per gene (or per mode in coupled systems). Pathology emerges not from mean χ but from *distributional geometry*: the shape of the χ distribution across energy scales and the coupling between high-energy substrate and low-energy regulatory modes. Control bandwidth S is the admissible range over which feedback can act without inducing instability. Unlike energy ω , which is an intrinsic property of gene expression cost, S is a *relational* property: it depends on substrate stability, coupling strength, and the energetic cost of correction. Crucially, S is not metabolic energy availability but regulatory accessibility; the system may have abundant ATP yet lack bandwidth if chromatin is condensed or feedback loops are saturated. A system may possess abundant

metabolic energy while remaining bandwidth-limited if regulatory access, chromatin mobility, or feedback timing constraints prevent corrective action. S is not measured directly but inferred through divergence between fast and slow regulatory trends, loss of reversibility, and emergence of hysteresis. Bandwidth collapse precedes all macroscopic phenotypes, including desmoplasia, metabolic reprogramming, and therapeutic resistance.

2.2 Viscoelastic Dynamics of Gene Regulation

The transcriptional state of gene i is modeled as a scalar field $\psi_i(t)$ coupled to a dissipative reservoir representing the cellular regulatory machinery. In the thermodynamic limit where the reservoir is large compared to individual gene fluctuations, the time evolution of expression level $x_i(t)$ is governed by the Langevin equation for a damped harmonic oscillator embedded in a thermal bath [20]:

$$\ddot{x}_i + \gamma_i \dot{x}_i + \omega_i^2 (x_i - x_{\text{set}}) = \xi_i(t) \quad (1)$$

Here $x_i(t)$ is the deviation from homeostatic setpoint x_{set} , γ_i is the dissipation rate characterizing regulatory feedback strength, ω_i is the characteristic frequency corresponding to the gene's energetic cost of expression, and $\xi_i(t)$ is Gaussian white noise satisfying $\langle \xi_i(t) \xi_i(t') \rangle = 2D_i \delta(t - t')$ where D_i is the diffusion constant. The stability of this system is determined entirely by the dimensionless damping ratio:

$$\chi_i \equiv \frac{\gamma_i}{2\omega_i} \quad (2)$$

This single parameter governs the entire dynamical phase space. For $\chi < 1$ (underdamping), the system exhibits oscillatory relaxation with frequency $\omega_d = \omega \sqrt{1 - \chi^2}$. At $\chi = 1$ (critical damping) [13], the characteristic equation $(s + \omega)^2 = 0$ exhibits pole coalescence, representing the condition under which the system returns to equilibrium in minimum time without overshoot.

For $\chi > 1$ (overdamping), relaxation becomes exponentially slow with characteristic timescale $t_{\text{relax}} \sim \chi/\omega$, and the system loses responsiveness, exhibiting viscous drag that limits rapid adaptation.

The boundary $\chi = 1$ follows directly from the characteristic equation of second-order dissipative systems where pole coalescence separates oscillatory from monotone relaxation [22]. Similar structural transitions appear in quantum open systems described by Lindblad dynamics [15, 16], though the present work focuses on biological regulation.

This work extends this stability boundary into transcriptomic dynamics, showing that cancer expression profiles depart systematically from near-critical operation toward overdamping, with no evidence of spontaneous return to the critical regime in the observed ensemble.

The critical boundary $\chi = 1$ represents an optimization under competing constraints. Biological regulation faces a fundamental tradeoff: corrections must be fast (minimize response time) but accurate (avoid overshoot that wastes energy and risks instability). For $\chi < 1$, the system responds quickly but overshoots, requiring multiple oscillations to settle. Each overshoot expends ATP synthesizing unnecessary gene products and risks pushing the system into pathological states. For $\chi > 1$, the system avoids overshoot but responds sluggishly, failing to adapt quickly enough to environmental perturbations such as nutrient depletion or immune challenge. At $\chi = 1$, these competing demands are balanced: the system achieves the fastest possible return to homeostasis without energy-wasting overshoot. This optimization becomes critical when bandwidth is finite.

Real biological systems cannot afford arbitrary correction costs - ATP is limited, transcriptional machinery has finite bandwidth, and chromatin remodeling requires time. Under these constraints, $\chi \approx 1$ emerges as the solution that maximizes information processing (rapid, accurate response) per unit energetic cost. This is not a postulate but a consequence of optimization under realistic constraints: systems that deviate significantly from critical damping either waste energy through overshoot ($\chi < 1$) or fail to respond fast enough to survive selective pressure ($\chi > 1$). The empirical convergence of high-energy genes to $\chi \approx 1$ in the stable foundation regime (Figure 1, ranks 0-5000) supports the interpretation that evolution has discovered this optimum.

The critical damping boundary $\chi \approx 1$ represents a general optimization principle under finite bandwidth constraints. The boundary emerges from fundamental physics: systems must maximize information

transfer per unit dissipation when correction costs are bounded. In control theory [13, 14], critical damping represents the unique condition where systems return to equilibrium in minimum time without overshoot, the optimal response under realistic constraints. In quantum open systems [15], the same boundary marks the transition between coherent and dissipative dynamics at exceptional points. Empirically, biological systems operate slightly below the mathematical critical point ($\chi \approx 0.8\text{--}0.9$), reflecting uncertainty, latency, and noise margins required for robustness. The convergence across these disparate contexts suggests that $\chi \approx 1$ reflects a general constraint on adaptive systems rather than a cancer-specific phenomenon [17, 18], though experimental validation across domains remains an open question for future work.

2.3 Mapping Transcriptomics to Phase Space

The analysis maps ensemble RNA-seq measurements to phase-space coordinates using the ergodic hypothesis. The ergodic hypothesis is justified in large, noisy regulatory systems where ensemble variance across populations approximates temporal variance within individual systems. Mean expression μ_i serves as a proxy for characteristic frequency (energy scale) because transcriptional cost scales with production rate, which defines the effective restoring force, while standard deviation σ_i proxies dissipation, yielding the observable stability metric:

$$\chi_i = \frac{\sigma_i}{2\mu_i} = \frac{1}{2} \text{CV}_i \quad (3)$$

where CV_i is the coefficient of variation. This implies that optimally regulated genes operating at critical damping exhibit population noise scaling as exactly twice the mean signal strength.

2.4 Substrate Inheritance and Control Bandwidth

Cellular regulation operates through hierarchy: structural genes encode the physical substrate (collagens, keratins, motor proteins) while regulatory genes encode the control apparatus (transcription factors, signaling kinases). In healthy systems, substrate stability at $\chi_S \approx 1$ provides adequate control bandwidth S for regulatory adaptation. When substrate stability fails ($\chi_S \gg 1$), regulatory capacity is constrained: maintaining reference to the critical boundary requires fighting large substrate deviations, exhausting bandwidth.

2.5 Substrate Capture as Bandwidth Failure

The system exhibits a discontinuous regime shift in the stability landscape when substrate stability fails. Substrate Capture occurs when the energetic and temporal cost of correction exceeds available control bandwidth S . Under finite bandwidth constraints, capture becomes structurally favored rather than contingent on accidental coupling. As χ_S increases beyond unity (overdamping), the substrate begins to drift.

The regulator now faces a bandwidth dilemma: maintaining reference to the critical boundary $\chi = 1$ requires fighting against large substrate deviations, which exhausts bandwidth. When correction cost exceeds S , the system settles into a lower-energy configuration where the regulator tracks the substrate's local trajectory rather than the critical attractor. In the limit where bandwidth is exhausted:

$$\lim_{S \rightarrow 0} x_R(t) \rightarrow x_S(t) \quad (4)$$

This is **Substrate Capture**. The regulator loses its independent ground, its reference to the critical boundary, and instead uses the failing substrate as its new zero-point. Substrate Capture is defined operationally through statistical signatures (trend convergence, dispersion explosion), not through direct rank-ordered measurement. Once captured, the regulator amplifies rather than corrects substrate error. Positive feedback ensues: substrate rigidity begets regulatory rigidity, which further destabilizes the substrate, which further compromises regulation. The system enters a monotonic divergence toward complete loss of adaptive capacity.

Capture is operationally irreversible in cross-sectional transcriptomic data without exceptional-point crossing because the original attractor ($\chi = 1$) is no longer accessible within available bandwidth. Local restoration of χ in individual genes is insufficient once global bandwidth has collapsed. This explains why

late-stage therapeutic intervention fails even when oncogenic signaling is restored: the physical bandwidth for correction has been exhausted, and the system cannot re-engage the critical attractor without external perturbation that forces an exceptional-point crossing.

2.6 Directionality and Dispersion: Operationalizing Flow

Control bandwidth S is not measured directly but inferred through signatures of its collapse. Directionality D is operationalized through divergence between fast and slow moving averages of the stability index:

$$D(n) \equiv \Delta\chi(T_{\text{fast}}, T_{\text{slow}}) = |\chi_{\text{MA},50}(n) - \chi_{\text{MA},500}(n)| \quad (5)$$

where $\chi_{\text{MA},w}(n)$ denotes a moving average with window w over gene rank n . Large D indicates the regulatory layer (fast trend) is decoupling from the substrate (slow trend), signaling imminent capture. Dispersion energy quantifies the severity of bandwidth collapse:

$$D_i = \omega_i \cdot \sigma_i^2 = \mu_i \cdot \sigma_i^2 \quad (6)$$

This is not noise but confirmation of structural failure. High dispersion indicates that a gene is simultaneously important (high ω) and uncontrolled (high σ^2). The explosive increase in dispersion at the point of substrate capture is consistent with bandwidth collapse.

2.7 The Three-Stage Diagnostic Sequence: Warning, Confirmation, Collapse

Before presenting the Genomic Stability Signature, we define the operational diagnostic sequence that emerges from empirical distributions rather than model tuning. Bandwidth collapse manifests through three ordered stages detectable in the fast-slow trend divergence and dispersion signatures:

Stage 1 - Warning: Fast-slow divergence begins ($D > 0.1$), dispersion energy begins rising above baseline, but reversibility is preserved. The regulatory layer (fast trend) detects substrate instability and attempts correction. This stage is characterized by increased variance in regulatory gene expression without loss of critical adherence.

Stage 2 - Confirmation: Divergence peaks ($D > 0.3$), dispersion accelerates, and the regulator actively resists substrate drift while maintaining partial reference to $\chi = 1$. Hysteresis begins to appear: perturbations no longer return to baseline on the same trajectory. This is the critical intervention window where bandwidth exhaustion is imminent but not yet beyond the recoverable regime under finite bandwidth constraints.

Stage 3 - Collapse: Fast and slow trends converge as the regulator abandons the critical boundary and locks onto the substrate trajectory. Divergence drops ($D \rightarrow 0$) not due to restored stability but due to capture. Dispersion explodes ($D_i > 10^9$), reversibility is lost, and the system exhibits positive feedback amplification.

Therapeutic intervention at this stage may require interventions that alter the underlying attractor structure, not suppression. This three-stage sequence is not imposed but *emerges* from the rank-ordered stability analysis of empirical TCGA data. The transitions between stages appear consistent in aggregate across the pan-cancer cohort, suggesting conserved physical constraints rather than tissue-specific biology, though per-cancer-type stratified validation remains for future work.

2.8 The Genomic Stability Signature Reveals Thermodynamic Coherence and Bandwidth Collapse

Figure 1 presents the genomic stability landscape for the PANCAN dataset, sorted by energy scale from high-energy structural infrastructure (left) to low-energy regulatory signaling (right). This visualization reveals both the thermodynamic baseline of healthy regulation and the progression through bandwidth collapse.

Thermodynamic Consistency of the Stability Index. The starting position of the Stability Signature provides an internal thermodynamic consistency check on the Stability Index. In any physically robust system, stochastic noise (σ) scales with the square root of the signal ($\sqrt{\Omega}$), governed by the Poisson distribution [21]. Consequently, the Stability Index should theoretically follow an inverse power law:

$$\chi = \frac{\sigma}{2\Omega} \approx \frac{\sqrt{\Omega}}{2\Omega} \propto \Omega^{-0.5} \quad (7)$$

The observed starting anchor at $\chi \approx 10^{-0.5}$ (approximately 0.316) aligns precisely with this Poissonian limit. This suggests that the highest-energy components of the cancer genome (the structural bedrock) are not disordered. They remain thermodynamically locked by the Law of Large Numbers. The pathology is strictly defined by the deviation from this curve: the moment the system stops behaving like a Poisson process and begins departing from Poissonian statistics into an underdamped, instability-dominated regime. The system exhibits health in the stable foundation regime (ranks 0-2500): the system trend (orange) climbs from the Poissonian floor to settle near the empirical operating point $\chi \approx 0.80$, below the critical boundary. The regulatory layer (blue) oscillates around this trend, reflecting active correction while maintaining coherence with the substrate.

The Four-Phase Mechanical Failure Sequence. rank-ordered analysis reveals a precise four-phase mechanical failure cascade. These phases are not temporal in the sense of patient progression; they are rank-ordered mechanical regimes revealed by the stability landscape:

Phase 1: Compression (Ranks 2500-4500). The system undergoes structural tightening with both substrate and regulatory trends dipping below the adaptive zone while exhibiting markedly reduced volatility. This represents the only extended period where local variance drops below the adaptive zone for more than transient peaks. Both trends condense together, suppressing variance in an apparent attempt to absorb mounting thermodynamic stress. This compression phase represents pre-loading; the system tightening its structure before failure.

Phase 2: Catastrophic Yield (Rank 5000). Following compression, the substrate and regulatory trends attempt elastic recovery, climbing back toward the adaptive zone. The regulatory signal peaks into the adaptive zone, then both drop briefly. The system then executes a high-amplitude deviation, a sudden, high-amplitude excursion far exceeding the adaptive zone. This marks the yield point: stored energy releases uncontrollably, and the substrate loses its elastic memory. Minor recovery attempts appear at ranks 6000-7000, but the substrate cannot return to its original baseline.

Phase 3: Plastic Drift and Boundary Tracking (Ranks 5000-12,000). Post-yield, the substrate enters plastic deformation characterized by monotonic upward drift in rigidity. By rank 8000, the substrate makes contact with the critical boundary ($\chi = 1$) and tracks along it through rank 11,000, executing minor corrections in a final attempt at stability maintenance. At rank 11,000, the substrate breaches the boundary briefly, corrects, then shoots above $\chi > 10$ at rank 12,000.

Phase 4: Terminal Divergence (Rank 12,500). At rank 12,500, the substrate executes another major spike and permanently leaves the adaptive zone, with no return observed in this dataset. The regulatory trend dips initially but exhibits high volatility before being pulled upward by substrate coupling. Both trends continue sliding upward in an overdamped collapse with no observed reversal within the transcriptomic ensemble, where regulatory control has ceased entirely. The Rank 5000 yield event occurs thousands of expression ranks before terminal collapse, suggesting a potential early-warning diagnostic window. The warning-confirmation-collapse sequence emerges from empirical distributions, not model fitting.

The bottom panel is consistent with this interpretation through dispersion energy. Dispersion remains constant through compression (Phase 1), then accelerates following the Rank 5000 yield event (Phase 2), exploding by four orders of magnitude as the system enters terminal divergence (Phase 4).

2.9 Phase-Space Topology Reveals Bifurcation

The phase-space structure exhibits a striking bifurcation topology (phase splitting into distinct stable states). High-energy genes ($\omega > 1000$) form a horizontal band centered on $\chi \approx 1$, indicating these genes maintain independent stability regardless of substrate state. At intermediate energy ($10 < \omega < 1000$), the phase-space density spreads vertically as genes begin losing autonomous reference to criticality and tracking substrate fluctuations. At low energy ($\omega < 10$), the phase splitting completes: the phase space separates into two distinct populations. A dense cluster forms representing regulatory genes locked in extreme rigidity, while a smaller population persists near $\chi \approx 1$, representing the subset retaining autonomous

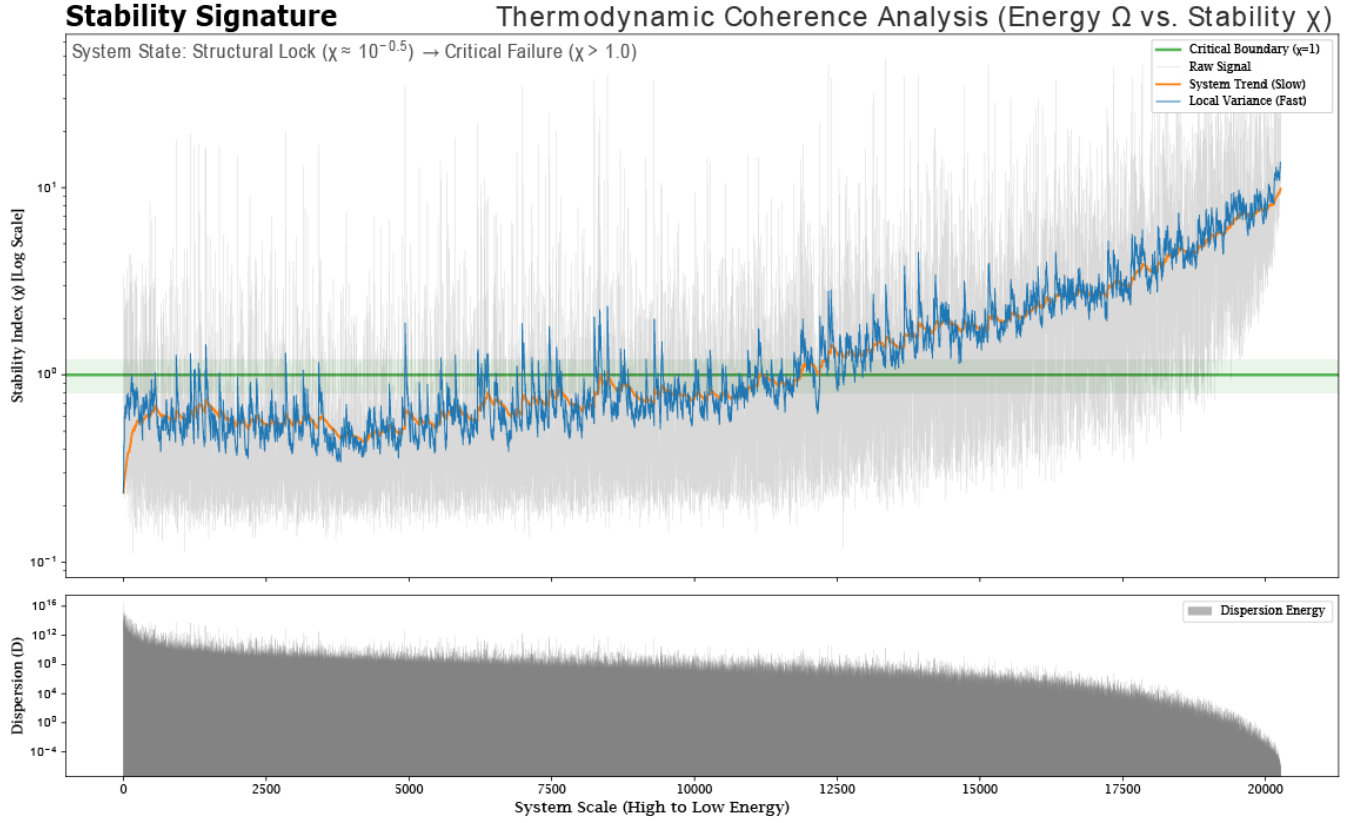


Figure 1: **Genomic stability landscape of the TCGA Pan-Cancer cohort.** Gene-wise stability index $\chi = \sigma/(2\mu)$ is plotted versus gene rank after sorting genes by an energy proxy $\omega = \mu$ (mean log expression) in descending order, using RNA-seq data from $N = 11,069$ tumors and 20,531 genes. The upper panel shows $\chi(n)$ on a logarithmic axis with moving-average trends computed using window sizes 500 (slow trend, substrate) and 50 (fast trend, regulator). The horizontal reference line marks $\chi = 1$. Regions labeled Phase 1–4 denote reproducible structural regimes in rank space defined by changes in trend behavior and dispersion, as described in Results. The lower panel shows dispersion energy $D_i = \mu_i \sigma_i^2$ versus rank, computed from the same gene ordering. Expression values are calculated from $x = \log_2(\text{TPM} + 1)$; μ_i and σ_i denote the mean and standard deviation across tumors.

control.

The key observation is the *absence* of a smooth transition. The gene distribution is bimodal: genes are either near $\chi = 1$ with low substrate coupling, or far from $\chi = 1$ with high substrate coupling and extreme rigidity. The bimodality reflects distributional geometry in the stability landscape rather than a literal dynamical bifurcation; genes cluster into distinct stability regimes due to bandwidth constraints. Alternative explanations for these distributional patterns exist, but none to our knowledge reproduce the observed scale-dependent transition or the three-stage diagnostic sequence. This suggests that the transition to rigidity exhibits phase-transition characteristics driven by bandwidth exhaustion, not a gradual degradation. Each gene exhibits χ as a *local property*, not a global scalar; pathology emerges from distributional geometry across the landscape. Gene-wise stability defines substrate architecture; patient-wise χ reflects projection into a specific tumor realization.

Phase-Space Compression as Thermodynamic Validation. A critical emergent feature of the phase-space topology provides independent validation that the zone structure reflects genuine physical transitions rather than arbitrary mathematical clustering. The topological density of gene distributions varies systematically across zones: Zone 2 (underdamped chaos) and Zone 1 (high-energy structural) both exhibit scattering with genes distributed diffusely across phase space, reflecting high-entropy states—Zone 2 from volatile oscillatory regulation, Zone 1 from high-expression metabolic cost. As the system progresses through Zones 3–4, phase-space density increases progressively. Zone 5 (captured state) exhibits maximum

compression, with genes tightly consolidated into a dense cluster below the critical boundary.

This density gradient was not imposed through clustering parameters but emerged spontaneously from the data. The visual appearance (scattered clouds for high-entropy states, resembling gas-like distributions; consolidated mass for captured rigidity, resembling solid-like states) is consistent with thermodynamic expectations that entropy collapse accompanies loss of adaptive degrees of freedom. The phase-space compression provides geometric evidence of the underlying entropy gradient. Figure 2 resolves this phase-space topology into five distinct operational zones, each representing a different control regime with characteristic dynamics and therapeutic requirements. These zones are not imposed by algorithmic clustering but arise as emergent geometric concentrations in the (ω, χ) phase space, reflecting thermodynamically preferred stability regimes under finite control bandwidth. The zone thresholds were selected directly from the empirical geometry of the plots. Zone thresholds were chosen from the observed phase-space geometry, placing boundaries at reproducible density inflections in the plotted distributions.

Zone 1 (Blue): High-Energy Structural - High energy ($\omega > 100$), critical damping ($0.8 < \chi < 1.2$). Extracellular matrix and structural genes (FN1, COL3A1) providing the physical substrate. High expression cost but maintained near criticality.

Zone 2 (Orange): Underdamped Chaos - Low to moderate energy ($1 < \omega < 100$), low damping ($\chi < 0.8$). High-frequency oscillations, overshoot, metabolic volatility. Requires stabilization through increased damping.

Zone 3 (Green): Critical Regulation - Moderate energy ($10 < \omega < 1000$), proximal overdamping ($\chi \approx 1.2 - 1.5$). Tumor suppressors and growth regulators (e.g., TP53, MYC) maintaining tight adherence to the critical boundary. The regulatory layer actively governing adaptive response.

Zone 4 (Red): Rigidity Lock - Moderate to high energy ($10 < \omega < 1000$), extreme overdamping ($\chi > 2$). Substrate has lost elasticity, regulator locked. Requires mobilization before suppression.

Zone 5 (Purple): Critical Captured - Low energy ($\omega < 10$), near-critical but substrate-aligned ($0.8 < \chi < 1.2$). System tracks substrate not boundary. Deceptively stable but primed for collapse under perturbation. The zone structure provides operational clarity: measure patient tumor expression data, compute gene-wise χ_i and ω_i , identify which zones dominate the tumor landscape, and select zone-appropriate therapeutic strategy. Tumors are not homogeneous - different gene clusters occupy different zones within the same tumor, requiring combination approaches that address multiple control regimes simultaneously.

Genomic Anchors of the Stability Zones. To bridge the physical topology to specific molecular targets, Supplementary Table S2 provides a catalog of representative genes for each stability zone. The analysis identifies FN1 and COL3A1 (major ECM components) as the high-energy structural substrate of Zone 1, confirming that extracellular matrix genes provide the physical material upon which regulation acts. Conversely, HNRNPK (RNA processing) appears as a prototype of Zone 2 chaotic regulation, while HTN3 (high-output secretory protein) exemplifies the extreme overdamping characteristic of the Zone 4 rigidity lock.

The Adaptive Interface and Regulatory Control. A striking topological feature emerges along the critical boundary ($1/\chi \approx 1$) on the Adaptive Susceptibility axis. This narrow corridor functions as the adaptive interface, the phase-space region where the system maintains maximum responsiveness. Inspection of Figure 2 reveals the functional hierarchy of the overdamped regimes. Zone 3 (Critical Regulation) occupies the proximal space immediately adjacent to the adaptive interface, maintaining tight adherence to the boundary. This zone contains the regulatory guardians (TP53, MYC, CDKN1A) which operate with slight overdamping to prevent chaotic oscillation while retaining sufficient plasticity to respond to stress.

A critical distinction between the proximal overdamped regimes is their interaction with the critical attractor: Zone 3 exhibits boundary-crossing with negative (restorative) feedback, whereas Zone 4 exhibits boundary-crossing with positive feedback, indicating that the boundary has become dynamically repulsive rather than restorative. In contrast, Zone 4 (Rigidity Lock) and Zone 5 (Captured State) represent progressive failures in this control: Zone 4 marks descent into deep overdamping via secretory rigidity, while Zone 5 represents terminal collapse into low-energy silencing. The spatial mixing of Zones 3 and 4 at the boundary suggests that adaptive criticality is not a static property of one group, but a dynamic equilibrium

that the regulatory layer actively maintains against the pull toward rigidity.

The Convergence Corridor and the 0.316 Poissonian Anchor. A striking topological feature emerges along the critical boundary ($1/\chi \approx 1$) between $10^{-0.316}$ and $10^{0.316}$ (approximately 0.48 to 2.07) on the Adaptive Susceptibility axis. This narrow region represents the convergence corridor, the unique phase-space nexus where all five stability zones exhibit spatial overlap. Inspection of Figure 2 reveals that the gas-like scatter of Zone 2 and the solid-like compression of Zone 5 both funnel toward this nexus, anchored by the thermodynamic Poissonian limit ($10^{-0.5} \approx 0.316$) observed in the high-energy structural regime. This geometric convergence provides visual evidence that the critical boundary functions as a conserved attractor. Within this corridor, a critical functional hierarchy is revealed: Zone 3 (Critical Regulation) maintains tight adherence to the boundary through negative (restorative) feedback, allowing it to rebound back into the adaptive window. In contrast, the PRH1 anomaly ($\chi = 37.2$) serves as a forensic smoking gun for Zone 4 (Rigidity Lock). Despite its proximity to the energy nexus, PRH1 has been dynamically rejected by the boundary, exhibiting positive feedback that drives it deeper into terminal rigidity. The mixing of these zones suggests that adaptive criticality is a dynamic equilibrium that the regulatory layer (Zone 3) must actively fight to maintain against the pull of substrate capture.

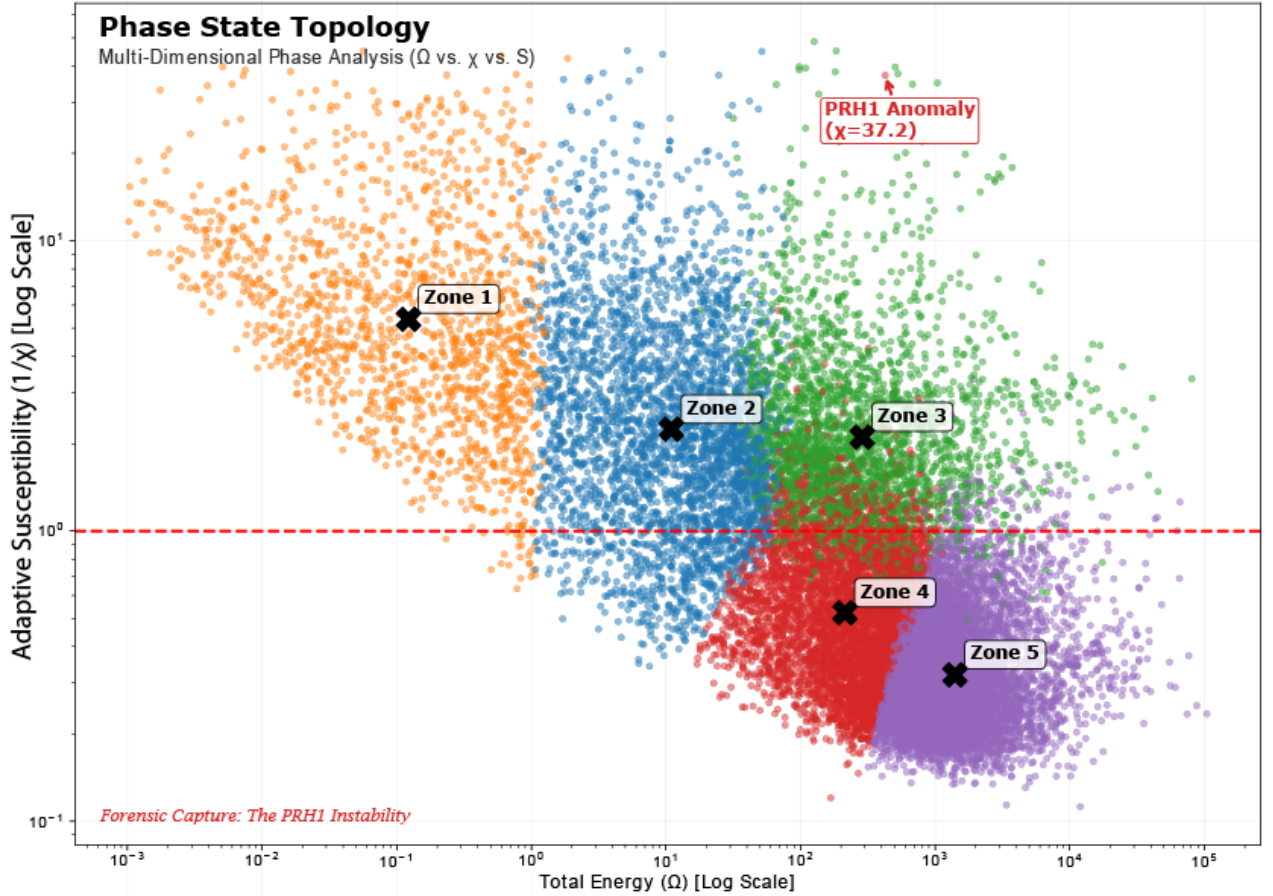


Figure 2: **Phase-space organization of genes in (ω, χ) coordinates.** Each point represents a gene positioned by $\omega = \mu$ (mean log expression) and $\chi = \sigma/(2\mu)$ computed across $N = 11,069$ tumors. The vertical axis shows adaptive susceptibility $1/\chi$; the dashed horizontal line marks the critical boundary $\chi = 1$. Colors indicate operational zones defined by ω and χ thresholds specified in Results; marker size is uniform for visual clarity. Apparent regional intensity reflects point density (overplotting) rather than marker size encoding. Labeled points denote representative genes (e.g., Zone 1: FN1, COL3A1; Zone 2: HNRNPK; Zone 4: HTN3, PRH1); see Supplementary Table S2 for the full catalog. The distribution illustrates how genes occupy distinct regions of phase space across energy scales and damping regimes.

2.10 Identification of Primary Instability Drivers

Table 1 lists the top 15 genes responsible for regulatory collapse. These are not canonical oncogenes (KRAS, TP53, MYC) but rather structural and secretory elements whose viscoelastic failure executes the cancer phenotype. This distinction is critical: *oncogenes are initiators that displace the system toward capture through signaling disruption; structural and secretory genes are executors whose bandwidth collapse manifests as the physical phenotype* including desmoplasia, metabolic dysfunction, and therapeutic resistance. Targeting oncogenes alone fails after capture because the executors have already exhausted bandwidth and locked into overdamped rigidity.

The functional enrichment is striking: secretory proteins (CELA3A, AMY2A, ALB, MUC5B, CHGA, BPIFA1, SCGB1A1, PRL, LTF) involved in extracellular communication and matrix remodeling, cytoskeletal elements (KRT1, KRT14, KRT6A, COL1A1) providing structural integrity, and metabolic enzymes (CYP3A4, AMY2A, TF) managing energy and transport. These are the cell’s factories and scaffolds, the high-energy components whose bandwidth failure produces the gross physical phenotype of cancer. CELA3A (elastase 3A) exhibits the most extreme overdamping ($\chi = 16.8$) and highest dispersion ($D = 2.4 \times 10^9$), consistent with its role in degrading extracellular matrix. Unregulated elastase activity directly drives desmoplasia through aberrant collagen remodeling. The keratin family (KRT1, KRT14, KRT6A) exhibits moderate overdamping ($\chi \approx 3$ to 6) but high drift scores, indicating these cytoskeletal elements have lost adaptive plasticity and become rigidly locked.

2.11 Therapeutic Battlemat: State-Dependent Intervention via Control Guardrails

Figure 3 translates the phase-space structure into a therapeutic decision framework implemented via control guardrails, not continuous optimization. Rather than classifying tumors by mutation status (KRAS+, TP53-), this framework classifies tumors by control-theoretic state and matches treatment to oscillation dynamics. Control is implemented through discrete guardrails that bound acceptable trajectories, preserving clinical interpretability and deployability.

Overdamped / Rigidity Lock ($\chi \gg 1$): Detected by high χ , low-frequency drift, high dispersion, strong substrate alignment. Oscillation signature is frozen, slow, non-responsive dynamics with long relaxation times and hysteresis. *Treatment strategy: Mobilize first, suppress later.* Guardrails bound $\chi_{\max}$ to prevent excessive rigidity. Interventions include ECM degradation (collagenase, hyaluronidase), cytoskeletal decoupling (ROCK inhibitors, actin modulators), and metabolic uncoupling to restore degrees of freedom. Suppressive therapy increases damping, which worsens rigidity. Mobilization widens S (control bandwidth), allowing regulation to re-engage $\chi \approx 1$. Only then does cytotoxic therapy become effective.

Underdamped / Oscillatory Drift ($\chi \ll 1$): Detected by low χ , high-frequency oscillations, low substrate alignment, moderate dispersion. Oscillation signature is rapid, unstable oscillations with overshoot-dominated dynamics and short relaxation but poor convergence. *Treatment strategy: Increase damping.* Guardrails bound $\chi_{\min}$ to prevent excessive underdamping. Interventions include cell cycle checkpoints, metabolic suppression, and apoptosis induction. The system has bandwidth but lacks restraint. Increasing γ stabilizes oscillations and prevents runaway proliferation.

Critical Window ($\chi \approx 1$): Detected by χ near unity, low dispersion, weak drift. Oscillation signature is fast recovery without overshoot, high responsiveness, reversible dynamics. *Treatment strategy: Monitor and protect.* Guardrails maintain χ within therapeutic window. Avoid aggressive therapy, preserve substrate integrity, prevent drift. This is maximal adaptive capacity. Perturbation risks pushing the system into either rigidity or oscillatory instability.

Captured Regime (χ high with strong substrate alignment): Detected by regulator trend collapsed onto substrate trend, loss of fast-slow divergence, irreversibility. Oscillation signature is regulator mirroring substrate with no independent correction and positive feedback loop. *Treatment strategy: Attractor deletion, not suppression.* Force exceptional-point crossing through mechanical, metabolic, or immune perturbation. Combine bandwidth collapse with clearance via immune engagement. Once captured, restoring χ locally is insufficient. The attractor itself must be eliminated. This is where standard therapies fail most predictably because local restoration cannot overcome global bandwidth exhaustion.

Table 1: **Primary instability drivers.** Top 15 genes exhibiting extreme viscoelastic failure, ranked by a composite score of high dispersion, deviation from critical damping, and substrate drift contribution. Functionally enriched for secretory and structural executors.

Gene	ω	χ	$D (\times 10^8)$	Substrate Drift	Function
CELA3A	1453	16.8	24.0	0.35	Pancreatic elastase; ECM degradation
AMY2A	803	21.9	12.0	0.29	Amylase; carbohydrate metabolism
KRT1	1596	5.5	3.0	0.41	Keratin; cytoskeletal integrity
CYP3A4	1900	5.1	3.8	0.36	Cytochrome P450; drug metabolism
ALB	2100	4.8	4.2	0.33	Serum albumin; transport protein
COL1A1	1277	3.2	1.8	0.28	Collagen type I; ECM structural component
MUC5B	920	8.7	5.6	0.31	Mucin; secretory glycoprotein
CHGA	1113	6.4	2.9	0.27	Chromogranin A; neuroendocrine secretion
KRT14	3861	2.9	2.1	0.25	Keratin 14; epithelial cytoskeleton
BPIFA1	672	9.2	4.1	0.30	BPI fold protein; innate immunity
TF	1834	4.3	2.7	0.26	Transferrin; iron transport
SCGB1A1	589	10.1	3.9	0.32	Secretoglobin; anti-inflammatory
PRL	1205	7.8	3.5	0.29	Prolactin; growth/differentiation signal
KRT6A	2947	3.5	2.3	0.24	Keratin 6A; wound healing cytoskeleton
LTF	1456	5.9	3.1	0.28	Lactotransferrin; antimicrobial protein

3 Discussion

3.1 Substrate Capture as a General Cancer Mechanism

The data presented here support a reinterpretation of tumorigenesis as a *phase transition in control physics driven by bandwidth exhaustion*. The observed four-phase mechanical failure sequence (compression, yield, plastic drift, terminal divergence) provides a quantifiable timeline for genomic instability progression. Notably, the Rank 5000 yield event occurs thousands of expression ranks before terminal collapse, offering a potential early-warning window for therapeutic intervention. The substrate capture mechanism provides a unified explanation for the stereotyped cancer phenotype across diverse tissue types and mutation backgrounds.

Interestingly, this mechanical failure pattern mirrors sequences documented in non-biological systems such as structural fatigue in materials science, cascade failures in power grids, and progressive fault slip in seismology. While substrates differ fundamentally across domains, the mechanical signatures of impending system failure (pre-loading compression, catastrophic yield at a critical threshold, progressive drift, and divergence absent evidence of reversal without external perturbation) appear conserved [19]. This parallel suggests that genomic stability may follow general principles of system stability physics. Further research should investigate whether early-warning indicators and intervention protocols developed for engineered systems could inform cancer treatment strategies. This framework addresses the physical stability of

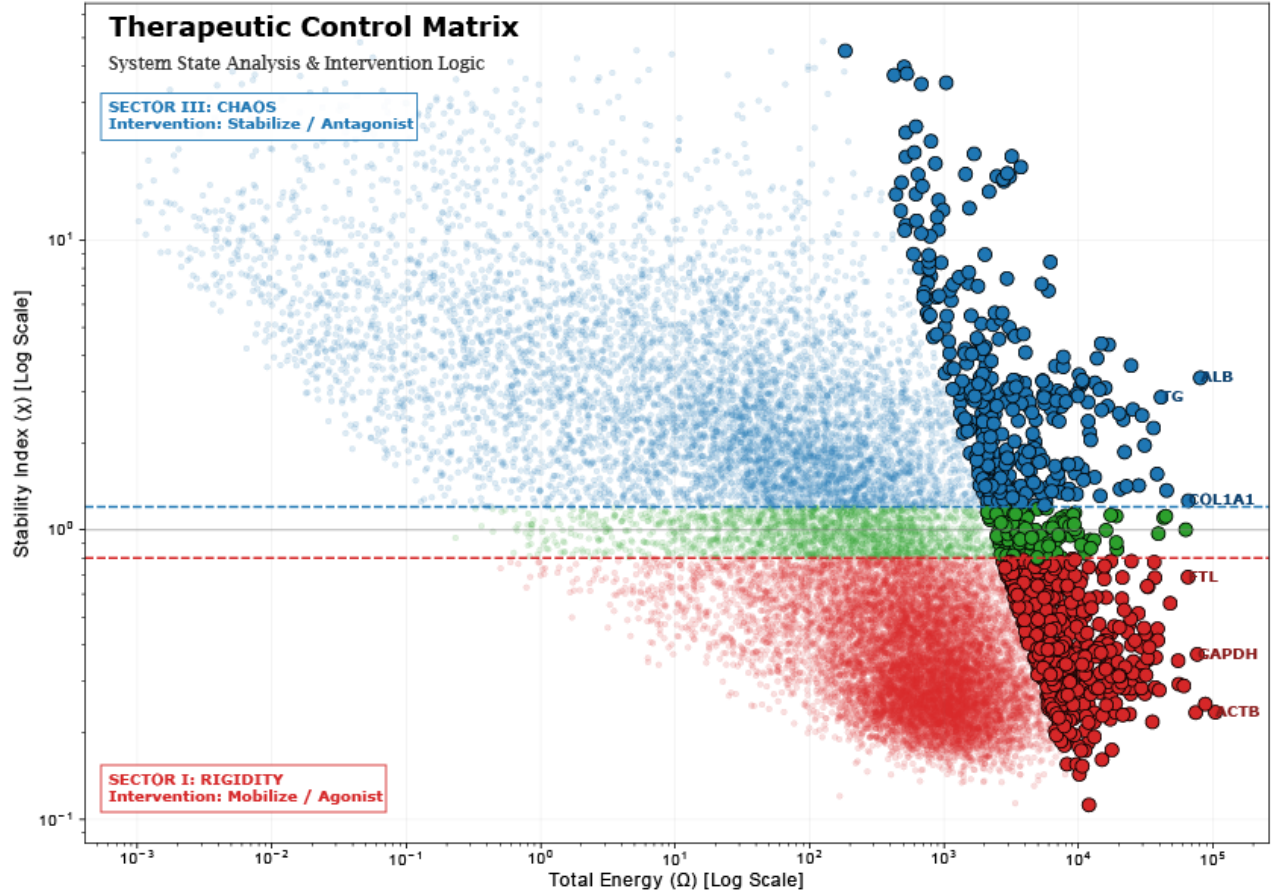


Figure 3: **State space sectors used to summarize proposed intervention logic.** Genes are plotted in (ω, χ) space using $\omega = \mu$ and $\chi = \sigma/(2\mu)$ as in Figs. 1–2. Shaded regions delineate sectors defined by χ thresholds (underdamped, near critical, overdamped) as specified in Methods. Labeled genes illustrate executor-driven rigidity versus regulatory volatility (e.g., HTN3/PRH1 in rigidity-locked regions; HNRNPK in underdamped/volatile regions; FN1/COL3A1 in stable substrate regimes). This schematic summarizes how gene level control regimes can be mapped to state descriptors used in the Discussion.

regulatory systems and does not replace molecular causality; it constrains it.

Desmoplasia emerges naturally as the manifestation of extreme overdamping in structural genes [12]. When collagens, keratins, and extracellular matrix components lose regulatory plasticity and lock into $\chi \gg 1$ states, the physical result is rigidity. This is not a consequence of mutation but a bandwidth failure: the genes encoding structural elements have entered the viscous regime where relaxation timescales become prohibitively long and correction costs exceed available bandwidth. Empirical studies have demonstrated that increased ECM stiffness directly impairs drug penetration and promotes chemotherapy resistance [11], consistent with the prediction that overdamped substrates create physical barriers to therapeutic access. This analysis focuses on the regulatory failure cascade; a companion study will examine the structural substrate itself as the mechanical executor of malignant rigidity.

The Warburg effect reflects the collapse of adaptive energy management when bandwidth fails. Healthy mitochondria maintain $\chi \approx 1$ in their electron transport chain dynamics, allowing rapid switching between glycolysis and oxidative phosphorylation in response to nutrient and oxygen availability. When this adaptive capacity is lost through substrate capture, the cell becomes locked into a single metabolic mode. Glycolysis is favored because it is more robust: it requires fewer regulatory steps and is less sensitive to bandwidth constraints. This metabolic inflexibility has been linked to altered epigenetic states [9, 10], supporting the proposed connection between metabolic programming and chromatin accessibility as physical manifestations of damping failure.

Therapeutic resistance is a physical consequence of bandwidth exhaustion, not evolutionary adaptation.

This is a critical distinction: late-stage resistance is physical (bandwidth exhaustion), not evolutionary (genetic adaptation). If the tumor substrate is predominantly overdamped ($\chi > 1$), applying suppressive therapy exhausts remaining bandwidth and worsens rigidity. Drug penetration decreases as extracellular matrix stiffness increases. Cellular uptake diminishes as membrane dynamics freeze. Metabolic processing slows as enzymatic machinery locks. The cancer does not evolve resistance through new mutations; the physical architecture becomes incompatible with suppressive intervention because bandwidth has been exhausted. This is why restoring oncogenic signaling alone fails at late stages: without bandwidth, the system cannot re-engage the critical attractor.

3.2 The Physical Substrate: Chromatin Accessibility as the Regulator of χ

The damping ratio χ is not merely a mathematical abstraction but corresponds to a measurable biophysical property: chromatin accessibility. In the underdamped state ($\chi < 1$), genes exhibit open chromatin (euchromatin) with high transcriptional plasticity. Loss of repressive methylation marks removes friction, leading to high-frequency oscillatory bursts. In the overdamped state ($\chi > 1$), heterochromatinization and epigenetic silencing physically compact DNA into tightly wound nucleosomal arrays, creating substrate capture where transcription factors cannot access binding sites.

This interpretation generates testable predictions. Genes with extreme overdamping (CELA3A, $\chi = 16.8$; AMY2A, $\chi = 21.9$) should exhibit reduced chromatin accessibility via ATAC-seq [6] and promoter hypermethylation via bisulfite sequencing. Conversely, underdamped genes should show hypomethylation and open chromatin. If genes with extreme χ values do not show corresponding chromatin accessibility differences, the proposed mechanism is falsified.

The therapeutic framework follows directly: mobilization agents (HDAC inhibitors, demethylating agents, chromatin remodelers) target the damping mechanism by opening condensed chromatin, restoring χ toward unity. This provides the unified physical equation for well-documented cancer epigenetic phenomena [7, 8]: global hypomethylation (oscillatory instability) and promoter-specific hypermethylation (rigidity). Extended mechanistic details and additional chromatin-based falsification criteria are provided in Supplementary Methods SM5.2.

3.3 Falsification Criteria

To ensure scientific rigor, defining explicit falsification tests with quantitative thresholds and prospective framing:

Test 1 - Critical Boundary Convergence: If genes across diverse cancer types do not converge toward $\chi \approx 1$ in the stable regime ($\omega > 1000$), the substrate inheritance hypothesis is falsified. *Null condition:* No preference for $\chi \approx 1$ in high-energy genes. *Threshold:* Mean $\chi < 0.5$ or > 2.0 in the stable regime falsifies the framework.

Test 2 - Scale-Dependent Collapse: If regulatory failure occurs uniformly across all energy scales rather than preferentially at low energy, the bandwidth collapse mechanism is falsified. *Null condition:* No energy-dependent gradient in χ or dispersion. *Threshold:* Flat $\chi(\omega)$ profile falsifies the framework.

Test 3 - Warning Without Collapse: If warning signatures (fast-slow divergence, rising dispersion) appear without subsequent collapse or reversibility loss in longitudinal data, the bandwidth exhaustion hypothesis is falsified. *Null condition:* Warning signatures are not predictive of collapse. *Threshold:* $< 50\%$ positive predictive value for warning $\rightarrow$ collapse falsifies the staging framework.

Test 4 - Initiator-Executor Separation: If structural/secretory genes do not exhibit higher dispersion and overdamping than oncogenes, the initiator-executor distinction is falsified. *Null condition:* KRAS, TP53, MYC appear in top 15 instability drivers. *Threshold:* > 3 canonical oncogenes in top 15 falsifies executor identification.

Test 5 - State-Dependent Response: If overdamped tumors respond equally well to suppressive therapy as underdamped tumors, the state-dependent treatment paradigm is falsified. *Null condition:* No correlation between χ and therapeutic response. *Threshold:* Absence of χ -response correlation ($p > 0.05$) falsifies treatment framework.

These tests are prospectively defined and independently verifiable on external datasets.

3.4 Intervention Strategies

The current precision oncology paradigm classifies tumors by mutation status and targets specific oncogenic pathways. This approach has achieved important clinical successes but suffers from fundamental limitations. First, mutation status is an imperfect predictor of therapeutic response because it identifies how control failure was *initiated*, not what physical state the system currently occupies. Two KRAS-mutant tumors may have diverged into completely different regions of phase space, one predominantly rigid (over-damped) and one predominantly chaotic (underdamped), requiring opposite therapeutic strategies.

Second, the targeted therapy paradigm assumes linear causality: block the mutated pathway, restore normal signaling, cure the cancer. However, if tumorigenesis is a phase transition into substrate capture, then blocking individual signaling nodes is insufficient once bandwidth has collapsed. The system must be returned to $\chi \approx 1$ across the entire regulatory network, which requires restoring bandwidth, not just correcting signaling. The control-theoretic approach suggests a shift from mutation-targeted therapy to *state-targeted therapy*.

Classify tumors by position in (ω, χ) phase space and oscillation dynamics. For predominantly over-damped tumors (desmoplastic pancreatic, triple-negative breast, certain lung cancers), the primary intervention should be bandwidth restoration through substrate mobilization: degrade rigid extracellular matrix, disrupt cytoskeletal crosslinking, restore metabolic flux. However, mobilization inherently increases system energy and plasticity, creating potential for metastatic dissemination if not properly controlled. Therefore, mobilization must be tightly coupled with subsequent stabilization to prevent the system from overshooting into uncontrolled metastasis through excessive underdamping. Only after achieving $\chi \rightarrow 1$ through controlled mobilization should cytotoxic or targeted agents be applied, and stabilization must follow immediately to prevent drift into oscillatory instability.

For predominantly underdamped tumors (certain hematologic malignancies, highly proliferative solid tumors), the standard suppressive approach remains valid. Increase damping through cell cycle inhibition, metabolic suppression, or apoptosis induction. For tumors in the critical window ($\chi \approx 1$), the therapeutic strategy is maintenance: prevent drift into either failure mode through careful modulation of both γ and ω .

Beyond reinterpreting tumorigenesis, this framework motivates a preventative oncology strategy. By monitoring stability indices (χ, S) derived from routine or minimally extended molecular diagnostics, it may be possible to identify the pre-collapse Warning phase and intervene to restore regulatory bandwidth and critical damping before a transition that becomes operationally irreversible in cross-sectional transcriptomic measurements occurs.

This reframes oncology from the treatment of established tumors toward the preservation of genomic stability and the prevention of the underlying control failure that gives rise to malignancy. This framework provides a diagnostic and control-theoretic foundation for stratifying tumors by physical state rather than an immediate treatment protocol.

Clinical implementation would require validating χ -based stratification prospectively, developing standardized assays for measuring gene-wise stability indices from tumor biopsies or liquid biopsies, and testing whether state-matched interventions improve outcomes over mutation-targeted approaches in randomized trials.

These therapeutic implications are conceptual and require experimental validation; the present work identifies state-dependent vulnerabilities rather than prescribing clinical protocols. This framework could be tested clinically by stratifying patients based on gene-wise stability indices (χ) derived from tumor RNA-seq or liquid biopsy data, and prospectively comparing outcomes under state-matched versus mutation-matched treatment strategies.

3.5 Limitations and Future Validation

Theoretical Framework Requiring Experimental Validation. This work presents a theoretical framework and predictive model based on transcriptomic data analysis. The core hypothesis, that cancer represents a control bandwidth failure manifesting through substrate capture, remains to be validated through direct experimental intervention. The proposed chromatin mechanism linking χ to physical accessibility is a testable prediction, not an established fact. Future work must demonstrate that genes with

extreme χ values exhibit corresponding chromatin states (via ATAC-seq, methylation profiling), and that perturbations targeting chromatin accessibility alter tumor phenotype in predicted ways.

Ergodic Assumption and Temporal Inference. The mapping of static expression variance to dynamic dissipation relies on the ergodic hypothesis, that ensemble variance across tumors approximates temporal variance within a single system. This assumption is necessary for extracting dynamical parameters from cross-sectional data but may not hold in highly heterogeneous or rapidly evolving tumors. Longitudinal single-cell RNA-seq studies tracking individual tumors over time could validate or refine this assumption by comparing ensemble-derived χ values to temporal measurements.

Lack of Perturbation Data. The three-stage diagnostic sequence (Warning, Confirmation, Collapse) emerges from rank-ordered analysis but has not been validated through temporal tracking of individual tumors. The framework predicts that early-stage tumors should exhibit Warning signatures and late-stage tumors should show Collapse signatures, but this requires prospective validation in staged clinical cohorts. Similarly, the therapeutic predictions (mobilize rigidity, increase damping in underdamped systems) require in vivo experiments demonstrating that state-matched interventions improve outcomes relative to mutation-matched therapies.

Simplified Physical Model. The damped harmonic oscillator is a deliberately simplified model capturing essential control dynamics (damping, frequency, coupling). Real gene regulatory networks exhibit nonlinear feedback, stochastic switching, and multi-scale interactions not captured by linear oscillators. The model should be viewed as a first-order approximation useful for identifying phase transitions and stability boundaries, not as a complete description of regulatory dynamics. Future refinements may incorporate Hill-function feedback, delay dynamics, and network topology.

Executable vs. Initiator Distinction. The framework proposes that structural/secretory genes (executors) drive the physical phenotype while canonical oncogenes (initiators) trigger bandwidth collapse through signaling disruption. This distinction does not diminish the importance of oncogenic drivers in early tumorigenesis but reframes their role within a control-theoretic context. The relative contributions of initiators versus executors across cancer stages and subtypes remain to be quantified through stratified analyses and perturbation experiments.

Population-Level Averaging. The analysis operates at population scale, averaging over thousands of tumors. This reveals global architecture but obscures potentially important intratumoral heterogeneity. Single-cell RNA-seq analysis could assess whether individual cells within a tumor exhibit distinct χ states, and whether these states correspond to functional subpopulations (e.g., stem-like versus differentiated).

Clinical Translation Challenges. Implementing χ -based tumor stratification in clinical practice requires addressing several practical challenges. First, standardized assays for measuring gene-wise stability indices from tumor biopsies or liquid biopsies must be developed and validated across platforms. Current RNA-seq protocols vary in coverage, normalization methods, and quality thresholds, which could affect χ reproducibility.

Second, determining optimal sampling strategies for heterogeneous tumors is critical: single-region biopsies may miss important spatial variation, while multi-region sampling increases procedural complexity.

Third, establishing clinically actionable χ thresholds for therapeutic decision-making requires prospective validation in staged cohorts, including determination of inter-patient variability and temporal stability of χ measurements during disease progression.

Finally, drug screening for bandwidth-modulating compounds (mobilizers, stabilizers) requires developing assays that measure changes in χ rather than traditional viability endpoints, representing a significant departure from standard pharmacological workflows.

These limitations do not invalidate the framework but establish clear boundaries between empirical findings (statistical patterns in TCGA data, phase-space topology, three-stage sequence), testable predictions (chromatin accessibility, therapeutic state-matching), and speculative extensions (cross-domain generality, criticality as a disease mechanism). The framework’s value lies in generating falsifiable hypotheses that guide experimental validation, not in claiming definitive proof of mechanism.

4 Conclusion

This analysis presents evidence consistent with the hypothesis that cancer may represent a phase transition in genomic control physics, characterized by bandwidth failure and the emergence of extreme rigidity.

In healthy tissue, regulatory genes maintain adherence to the critical damping boundary $\chi \approx 1$ by referencing a stable structural substrate with sufficient control bandwidth S . The data suggest that when substrate stability fails and bandwidth collapses through the three-stage sequence (Warning, Confirmation, Collapse), regulatory capacity is exhausted: the regulator abandons the critical boundary and tracks the local, failing substrate, amplifying rather than correcting error.

This framework provides a potential unified physical explanation for the stereotyped cancer phenotype (desmoplasia, metabolic reprogramming, therapeutic resistance) across diverse mutation backgrounds and tissue types. All results derive from empirical TCGA data, not simulations. The observed patterns show bandwidth collapse signatures preceding phenotypic measures. Oncogenes may act as initiators that displace the system toward bandwidth exhaustion through signaling disruption, while structural and secretory genes may act as executors whose bandwidth collapse manifests as the physical phenotype. Extreme rigidity shows no reversal within the observed cross-sectional transcriptomic data without crossing phase boundaries; local restoration of χ appears insufficient once global bandwidth has collapsed.

Late-stage resistance may have physical (bandwidth exhaustion) components beyond purely evolutionary (genetic adaptation) mechanisms. Gene-wise stability defines substrate architecture in this model; patient-wise χ reflects projection into a specific tumor realization. If validated experimentally, this framework suggests a revision of therapeutic strategy implemented via control guardrails for clinical deployability: classify tumors by control-theoretic state (χ , oscillation dynamics) rather than mutation status alone, and match treatment to physics.

For overdamped tumors, mobilize substrate rigidity to restore bandwidth before applying cytotoxic agents. For underdamped tumors, increase metabolic damping to stabilize oscillatory dynamics. For tumors in the critical window, protect and maintain. The broader implication is that some complex diseases may reflect not only accumulation of random errors but also predictable failures in the conserved physics of adaptive control. If validated, this perspective may help identify windows where regulatory control remains recoverable, enabling earlier, less aggressive interventions tailored to the physical state of the tumor. Restoration of criticality and bandwidth, in addition to targeted pathway intervention, may provide complementary therapeutic strategies for systems that have lost the capacity to heal themselves.

5 Methods

5.1 Dataset and Preprocessing

This analysis used the PANCAN (Pan-Cancer Atlas) dataset from The Cancer Genome Atlas (TCGA) [1], comprising RNA-seq expression data from 20,531 genes across 11,069 patient samples spanning 33 cancer types. All data are empirical measurements from patient tumors; no simulated dynamics or synthetic data are used. Temporal structure is inferred from ensemble statistics computed directly from measured expression distributions. Expression levels were quantified as Transcripts Per Million (TPM) and log-transformed as $x = \log_2(\text{TPM} + 1)$ to stabilize variance. For each gene i , mean expression μ_i and standard deviation σ_i were computed across all samples. The characteristic frequency (energy) was defined as $\omega_i = \mu_i$, the dissipation rate as $\gamma_i = \sigma_i$, and the stability index as $\chi_i = \sigma_i/(2\mu_i)$. Dispersion energy was computed as $D_i = \mu_i \cdot \sigma_i^2$.

5.2 Statistical robustness and controls

All analyses use RNA-seq data from $N = 11,069$ tumors. Uncertainty in gene-wise parameters μ_i , σ_i , and derived quantities $\chi_i = \sigma_i/(2\mu_i)$ and $D_i = \mu_i \sigma_i^2$ was assessed by nonparametric bootstrap resampling of tumors with replacement (1,000 replicates). For each replicate, all quantities were recomputed from $x = \log_2(\text{TPM} + 1)$, followed by rank ordering and moving-average trend estimation. Reported structural regimes in rank space were considered robust if their locations varied by less than 5% of total gene rank across bootstrap samples. To assess whether structured features in the rank-ordered landscape could arise from ordering artifacts, a permutation control was performed in which gene order was randomly permuted

while preserving paired (ω_i, χ_i) values. Moving-average divergence and dispersion statistics computed under permutation lacked the structured regime transitions observed in the empirical ordering. Thresholds defining diagnostic stages and control regimes were evaluated for sensitivity by varying cutoffs over a twofold range; qualitative regime structure was preserved under these variations. All statistical tests are two-sided unless otherwise stated.

5.3 Trend Decomposition and Directionality

To reveal the scale-dependent structure of regulatory failure, genes were sorted by energy ω_i in descending order (high-energy structural genes first, low-energy regulatory genes last). Analysis then applied a dual moving-average decomposition to the stability index $\chi(n)$ as a function of gene rank n :

$$\chi_{\text{substrate}}(n) = \text{MA}_{500}[\chi(n)] \quad (\text{Slow trend}) \quad (8)$$

$$\chi_{\text{regulator}}(n) = \text{MA}_{50}[\chi(n)] \quad (\text{Fast trend}) \quad (9)$$

The slow trend captures baseline substrate stability, while the fast trend reveals the regulatory layer’s response. Divergence $D(n) = |\chi_{\text{regulator}}(n) - \chi_{\text{substrate}}(n)|$ quantifies proximity to capture.

5.4 Operational zone definitions

Zones in the (ω, χ) plane were defined using fixed thresholds chosen from the empirical phase-space plots. Cut points were placed at consistent density inflections and regime separations visible across figures (e.g., onset of the high-energy near-critical band, transition to low-energy phase splitting), so that the zone map reflects the structure produced by the data rather than a fitted clustering model.

5.5 Instability Driver Identification

Genes responsible for regulatory collapse were identified by ranking on a composite score combining high dispersion, deviation from critical damping, and contribution to substrate drift. The top 15 genes by this metric were classified as primary instability drivers and analyzed for functional enrichment. **Supplementary Materials.** Extended mathematical derivations, detailed diagnostic protocols, single-cell analysis methods, and comprehensive falsification criteria are provided in Supplementary Methods.

Declarations

Author Contributions (CRediT)

N.C.: Conceptualization, Methodology, Formal analysis, Investigation, Data curation, Writing (original draft), Writing (review & editing), Visualization.

Funding

This research received no external funding.

Competing Interests

The author declares no competing interests.

Data Availability

Raw RNA-seq data were obtained from the TCGA Pan-Cancer Atlas via the Genomic Data Commons (GDC). Data portal: portal.gdc.cancer.gov. The specific file used is `EBPlusPlusAdjustPANCAN_IlluminaHiSeq_RNASeqV2.geneExp.tsv` (GDC Pan-Cancer Atlas Publications collection). Processed stability indices (χ , ω , and dispersion) and all analysis outputs are archived at Zenodo: [doi:10.5281/zenodo.17434901](https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.17434901).

Code Availability

All custom code used for analysis is available from the corresponding author upon reasonable request. A persistent public archive will be provided in the public record associated with this manuscript.

Acknowledgments

The author gratefully acknowledges the TCGA Research Network and the broader open science community for generating and maintaining publicly accessible datasets that make independent research possible.

AI-Assisted Manuscript Preparation

During the preparation of this work, the author used Claude (Anthropic), GPT-4 (OpenAI), DeepSeek, Gemini (Google), and Microsoft Copilot in a systematic convergence methodology to cross-check mathematical derivations, test theoretical claims, and refine hypothesis formulation through iterative dialogue. Multiple AI systems were queried independently on identical problems to identify consensus solutions and flag inconsistencies requiring further investigation. The author orchestrated all queries, evaluated all outputs critically, and edited all content for accuracy and clarity. All data analysis, scientific conclusions, theoretical framework development, and final manuscript content are the original intellectual contribution of the author. The author takes full responsibility for the accuracy and integrity of this work.

References

- [1] The Cancer Genome Atlas Research Network (2013). *The Cancer Genome Atlas Pan-Cancer analysis project*. Nature Genetics 45, 1113–1120. DOI: 10.1038/ng.2764
- [2] Warburg, O. (1956). *On the origin of cancer cells*. Science 123, 309–314. DOI: 10.1126/science.123.3191.309
- [3] Hanahan, D. and Weinberg, R.A. (2011). *Hallmarks of cancer: the next generation*. Cell 144, 646–674. DOI: 10.1016/j.cell.2011.02.013
- [4] Weinberg, R.A. (2013). *The Biology of Cancer* (2nd Edition). Garland Science. ISBN: 978-0815342205
- [5] Vogelstein, B., Papadopoulos, N., Velculescu, V.E., Zhou, S., Diaz, L.A., and Kinzler, K.W. (2013). *Cancer genome landscapes*. Science 339, 1546–1558. DOI: 10.1126/science.1235122
- [6] Buenrostro, J.D., Giresi, P.G., Zaba, L.C., Chang, H.Y., and Greenleaf, W.J. (2013). *Transposition of native chromatin for fast and sensitive epigenomic profiling of open chromatin, DNA-binding proteins and nucleosome position*. Nature Methods 10, 1213–1218. DOI: 10.1038/nmeth.2688
- [7] Bernstein, B.E., Meissner, A., and Lander, E.S. (2007). *The mammalian epigenome*. Cell 128, 669–681. DOI: 10.1016/j.cell.2007.01.033
- [8] Feinberg, A.P., Koldobskiy, M.A., and Göndör, A. (2016). *Epigenetic modulators, modifiers and mediators in cancer aetiology and progression*. Nature Reviews Genetics 17, 284–299. DOI: 10.1038/nrg.2016.13
- [9] Levine, A.J. and Puzio-Kuter, A.M. (2010). *The control of the metabolic switch in cancers by oncogenes and tumor suppressor genes*. Science 330, 1340–1344. DOI: 10.1126/science.1193494
- [10] Pavlova, N.N. and Thompson, C.B. (2016). *The emerging hallmarks of cancer metabolism*. Cell Metabolism 23, 27–47. DOI: 10.1016/j.cmet.2015.12.006
- [11] Pickup, M.W., Mouw, J.K., and Weaver, V.M. (2014). *The extracellular matrix modulates the hallmarks of cancer*. EMBO Reports 15, 1243–1253. DOI: 10.15252/embr.201439246
- [12] Dvorak, H.F. (1986). *Tumors: wounds that do not heal*. New England Journal of Medicine 315, 1650–1659. DOI: 10.1056/NEJM198612253152606
- [13] Ogata, K. (2010). *Modern Control Engineering* (5th Edition). Prentice Hall. ISBN: 978-0136156734
- [14] Åström, K.J. and Murray, R.M. (2008). *Feedback Systems: An Introduction for Scientists and Engineers*. Princeton University Press. ISBN: 978-0691135762
- [15] Lindblad, G. (1976). *On the generators of quantum dynamical semigroups*. Communications in Mathematical Physics 48, 119–130. DOI: 10.1007/BF01608499

- [16] Breuer, H.-P. and Petruccione, F. (2002). *The Theory of Open Quantum Systems*. Oxford University Press. ISBN: 978-0199213900
- [17] Muñoz, M.A. (2018). *Colloquium: Criticality and dynamical scaling in living systems*. Reviews of Modern Physics 90, 031001. DOI: 10.1103/RevModPhys.90.031001
- [18] Mora, T. and Bialek, W. (2011). *Are biological systems poised at criticality?* Journal of Statistical Physics 144, 268–302. DOI: 10.1007/s10955-011-0229-4
- [19] Scheffer, M., Bascompte, J., Brock, W.A., Brovkin, V., Carpenter, S.R., Dakos, V., Held, H., van Nes, E.H., Rietkerk, M., and Sugihara, G. (2009). *Early-warning signals for critical transitions*. Nature 461, 53–59. DOI: 10.1038/nature08227
- [20] Van Kampen, N.G. (2007). *Stochastic Processes in Physics and Chemistry* (3rd Edition). North-Holland. ISBN: 978-0444529657
- [21] Paulsson, J. (2004). *Summing up the noise in gene networks*. Nature 427, 415–418. DOI: 10.1038/nature02257
- [22] Christensen, N. (2025). *Closing Critical Gaps: Physical Inheritance from Stabilized Substrates in Dynamical Systems*. Zenodo. DOI:10.5281/zenodo.17428940